

Chhattisgarh within months. "Raman Singh and Mahendra Karma are both responsible for the mess," says Manish Khunjam, former MLA and secretary of the CPI-initiated Adivasi Mahasabha.

Dornapal hosts the largest camp of 16,500 people. A Deccan Airlines' helicopter, ferrying food to shelter-seekers, alights in a makeshift helipad. Rajesh Pawar, who belongs to the battery of 4,000 Special Police Officers (SPOs) fielded to counter the Maoists, inspects the supplies. A band of girls clad in military fatigues complains to Pawar about their salaries. The state government pays Rs 1,500 per month to each member of the Salwa Judum armed cell. Barring the

UNICEF which has sponsored an *anganwadi*, NGOs have kept off the camp. "The government is giving us food and a place to stay but this is a temporary arrangement," say Morkam Boja and Kunja Mura. The two men had fled Orgatta village after refusing to attend a Maoist meeting. "If you are not with us, you must be with them. They (Maoists) used to say and torture us," says Sariam Dule who also fled her village in Gagampallika. In November 2007, the south Bastar division commission of CPI (Maoist) wrote a letter urging refugees to return to their villages but fear seems to have paralysed many.

National Highway 43 is lined with refugee camps and abandoned villages. Konta is Chhattisgarh's border district with Orissa where concrete houses have replaced the thatched huts of migrants. "Many people were killed by the Maoists but now the situation has improved," says Soyam Muka, Konta's Salwa Judum president. The Konta camp has acquired the look of a semi-rural ghetto on the bank of river Savri, picturesque enough for Salwa Judum leaders to ride their swanky Boleros while drinking Salfi—the local liquor. Obviously, not all government funds are being put to good use. Guarded by CRPF and Mizoram Police battalions, the displaced continue to live in uncertainty. Away from the trepidation of camps and the jungle regime, villagers converge weekly on the outskirts of towns to enjoy cock fights. Tobacco chewing men and women bet on coloured, white and black cocks which fight one another with small knives tied to their limbs. The booty sometimes touches Rs 5,000.

HOMELESS: (Left) The Displaced in Dornapal relief camp; Salwa Judum guards in Konta



Almost 60,000 people from Maoist-controlled villages fled to 17 Salwa Judum camps across Chhattisgarh within six months in 2005

